



GLAXIT

INTERNSHIP PROGRAM

Advanced Cyber Security

Task 1 Report

Phishing Email Examples for Security Awareness

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Phishing Email Examples for Security Awareness

Simulated Examples and Indicator Analysis — Educational Report

Disclaimer

The two emails in this report are fictional simulations created for training and awareness purposes only. They use invented companies, names, and domains. They must not be sent, distributed, or used outside of this assignment. They exist solely to illustrate common phishing techniques and to support the indicator analysis that follows.

Purpose of This Report

Phishing remains one of the most common ways attackers gain a foothold inside an organization, because it targets people rather than technical defenses. This report presents two realistic, fictional phishing email examples, each built around a different social engineering technique, followed by an analysis of the specific indicators that reveal each message as fraudulent. The goal is to help readers recognize similar patterns in real inboxes.

Example 1: Fake IT Help Desk Email

Social engineering technique: Urgency and fear

Subject line	Urgent: Immediate Action Required – Your Password Expires Today
Sender name	IT Help Desk <ithelpdesk@corp-secure-support.com>
Target audience	Employees of a mid-to-large company with a corporate email/network login

Simulated Email

From: IT Help Desk <ithelpdesk@corp-secure-support.com>

Subject: Urgent: Immediate Action Required – Your Password Expires Today

Dear Employee,

Our system indicates that your network password will expire in the next 3 hours. To avoid losing access to your email, shared drives, and internal applications, you must reset your password immediately using the secure link below.

[\[Reset My Password Now \]](#)

If you do not update your credentials before the deadline, your account will be locked and you will need to submit a help desk ticket, which may take up to 5 business days to resolve.

This is an automated message. Please do not reply.

IT Help Desk

Phishing Indicators

- **Artificial time pressure** — a 3-hour deadline and threat of account lockout are designed to trigger panic and override careful judgment.
- **Generic greeting** — “Dear Employee” instead of the recipient's actual name; legitimate internal IT emails are usually personalized.
- **Mismatched sender domain** — a real company's IT desk would send from the company's own domain, not a lookalike such as “corp-secure-support.com.”
- **Exaggerated consequence** — a vague 5-business-day lockout makes clicking the link feel like the “safe” choice.
- **“Do not reply” instruction** — prevents the recipient from easily verifying the request through the same channel.
- **Single link as the only call to action** — rather than directing users to log in independently through a known company portal.

How to Recognize This as Phishing

Hover over (or long-press, on mobile) the link to see the actual destination URL before tapping — it will not match the company's real domain. Check the sender's full email address, not just the display name. Legitimate IT departments rarely give hour-long deadlines for password resets by email; when in doubt, contact IT directly using a known phone number or by typing the company portal's URL manually rather than clicking the link.

Example 2: Fake Gift Card Offer

Social engineering technique: Curiosity and reward

Subject line	You've Won! Claim Your Free \$100 Gift Card Today 🎁
Sender name	Customer Rewards <rewards@shopper-perks-bonus.com>
Target audience	General consumers (mass, untargeted phishing campaign)

Simulated Email

From: Customer Rewards <rewards@shopper-perks-bonus.com>

Subject: You've Won! Claim Your Free \$100 Gift Card Today 🎁

Congratulations!

Your email has been selected to receive a FREE \$100 gift card as a thank-you for being a loyal customer. This exclusive reward is only available to the first 100 people who respond.

To claim your gift card, click the link below and complete a short verification form with your name, address, and payment details for shipping confirmation.

[\[Claim Your Free Gift Card \]](#)

Hurry, this offer expires in 60 minutes!

Warm regards,

Customer Rewards Team

Phishing Indicators

- **Unsolicited, too-good-to-be-true reward** — there is no prior purchase or relationship explaining why this “loyal customer” was chosen.
- **Artificial scarcity and urgency** — “first 100 people” and a 60-minute expiration prevent the recipient from pausing to think.
- **Request for personal and payment information** — disguised as a “shipping confirmation”; a genuine gift card would not require a payment method.
- **Emotionally charged language and emoji** — “Congratulations!” and celebratory emoji are designed to provoke excitement over scrutiny.
- **Unrelated sender domain** — no connection to any brand the recipient recognizes.
- **Vague sender identity** — “Customer Rewards Team” with no company name, physical address, or verifiable contact information.

How to Recognize This as Phishing

Be skeptical of any unexpected prize, especially one that requires personal or payment details to “claim” it. Check whether the sender's domain matches a real, known company. Legitimate rewards or refund programs do not impose minute-by-minute deadlines. If curious, verify independently by logging into the real company's account or website rather than clicking through the email.

General Takeaways

- **Manufactured time pressure** — both examples use an artificial deadline to short-circuit critical thinking before the recipient can verify the request.
- **A single link as the call to action** — both messages funnel the recipient toward one click rather than an independently verified channel, one of the most common threads across real-world phishing.
- **Sender domain mismatches** — in both cases the sending domain does not match any organization the recipient would actually expect to hear from.

Recognizing these patterns — urgency, mismatched sender details, unsolicited rewards, and requests routed through a single link — is one of the most effective defenses against phishing, since these techniques recur across the vast majority of real-world campaigns regardless of their specific pretext.